

From: "Fauci, Anthony (NIH/NIAID) [E]" <AFAUCI@niaid.nih.gov>

To: "Lane, Cliff (NIH/NIAID) [E]" <CLANE@niaid.nih.gov>

Subject: FW: NYT: The Truth About the Doomsday Virus? <http://nyti.ms/ypF0RD>

Date: Sun, 04 Mar 2012 07:55:51 -0500

Importance: Normal

Cliff:

The article below relates to an editorial in today's N.Y. Times. Clearly, people are getting to Phil Boffey and he is swallowing it. I predicted this. The NSABB will circle the wagons and claim that their decision in no way was influenced by the fact that they did not realize that the aerosol-transmitted virus did not kill any ferrets or that the engineered virus was poorly transmissible compared to seasonal H1N1 or that the tracheal experiments required 100 X to 1000X the usual challenge dose to kill the ferrets or that prior infection with seasonal flu (even H3N2) protected the animals against tracheal challenge. They will say that it was the mere fact that the virus was made transmissible in ferrets when it was not transmissible before engineering and passage. If this is the case and they do not change their recommendation, the field of research on influenza transmissibility and host adaptability has a very serious problem. Please delete this e-mail and then delete from the deleted file.

Tony

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From: Fauci, Anthony (NIH/NIAID) [E]

Sent: Saturday, March 03, 2012 8:48 PM

To: Collins, Francis (NIH/OD) [E]

Subject: FW: NYT: The Truth About the Doomsday Virus? <http://nyti.ms/ypF0RD>

Francis:

Phil Boffey is really off base here. See yellow highlight. What is he talking about the NIH's reputation being on the line? The NSABB overwhelmingly agreed that the research was important and should have been funded by NIH. They recommended that the publication be restricted. We accepted their recommendation and began to implement it. Now we have additional and clarifying information from the Geneva Meeting and the ASM meeting and we want to give the NSABB the benefit of all of the information and time for further discussion. We are not asking them to change their mind; we just want them to have all of the information. We cannot say this publicly, but it is clear that essentially no one on the NSABB (certainly not its Chair) appreciated that the animals infected by aerosol did not get seriously ill and none of them died. The NSABB may well say that this confusion did not influence their decision and that they stick by their recommendation. That is their choice. But what does that have to do with the NIH's reputation? I had spoken to Phil Boffey after the ASM meeting since he called me to clarify some points about what was discussed at the ASM meeting. He e-mailed me tonight to give me a heads-up that the editorial was coming on Sunday. I called him up but got voice mail. I will give him a call first thing next week and find out what is on his mind. He is acting like a mischievous guy.

Talk to you tomorrow at 4:00 PM.

Thanks,
Tony

From: Folkers, Greg (NIH/NIAID) [E]

Sent: Saturday, March 03, 2012 6:14 PM

Subject: NYT: The Truth About the Doomsday Virus? <http://nyti.ms/ypF0RD>

Editorial

The Truth About the Doomsday Virus?

Published: March 3, 2012

Two months ago we warned that a new bird flu virus — modified in a laboratory to make it transmissible through the air among mammals — could kill millions of people if it escaped confinement or was stolen by terrorists. Now Ron Fouchier, the Dutch scientist who led the key research team, is saying that his findings, which remain confidential, were misconstrued by the press.

Related

- [Genetically Altered Bird Flu Virus Not as Dangerous as Believed, Its Maker Asserts](#) (March 1, 2012)
- **Health Guide:** [Avian Influenza](#)

He says that the virus did not spread easily and was not lethal when transmitted from one ferret to another by coughing or sneezing, and that it became highly lethal only when big doses were injected into the animals' windpipes.

That is hard to square with his original assertions. Experts who read his original manuscript say it reported that the new virus spread through the air and remained as virulent as the natural virus, which has killed 60 percent of the humans it has infected.

Dr. Fouchier's new claims are only the latest bizarre twist in a global health debate that badly needs an objective, independent arbiter. The public needs to know whether this virus is a potentially big killer, and if so, how it should be contained. It needs to know what details can be published without giving terrorists a recipe for a biological weapon. And it needs to know that a mechanism will be put in place to assess all the risks and benefits of such research before it is approved — not after a new virus has been created.

The debate became public after a federal advisory board, the National Science Advisory Board for Biosecurity, recommended that papers prepared by Dr. Fouchier's group and researchers doing similar work at the University of Wisconsin-Madison be published only after omitting details that might help terrorists. That drew charges of censorship from some scientists, and others warned that restricting the information would make it harder to track and combat an outbreak of a similar strain.

The World Health Organization convened a closed meeting of 22 experts last month, which concluded that the research should eventually be published in full. The group was dominated by participants with a clear stake in

Released by Chairman Rand Paul

publication — including the researchers who made the viruses, the journals that want to publish their papers in full, and developing countries that want access to full details in exchange for having contributed the viruses that were studied.

Now this country's National Institutes of Health, which financed the research and has its own reputation on the line, is asking the biosecurity advisory board to reconsider its call to redact details before publication.

We welcome a new appraisal from a board that has already shown considerable independence. We hope it will look beyond the security and terrorism issues and voice its opinion on what safety precautions should be required to prevent the virus from escaping and whether the work should proceed at multiple labs or possibly be halted.

These issues need to be resolved by experts who do not have institutional biases or turf to protect. The World Health Organization should be in the best position to oversee a response to what is a global problem. Its first effort was one-sided and disappointing, but it has pledged to convene further meetings with a much broader range of experts and interested parties. It must ensure that these forums are not rubber stamps for what the narrower special-interest group just concluded.

These are complicated issues, and the stakes are enormous. Governments and scientists have a clear responsibility to get this judgment and future efforts right.